



Shastri dish out anecdotes, and warm laughter ripples through the cold air.

One of India's training sessions is thrown open to the public. More than 3,000 turn up, and it is disconcerting for the players. Some fans get close to Rohit (**right**) to say hello; he requests them to move towards the far corner and watch. Days later, the Indian captain says: "If they want to see us, let them come to the Test matches!"

The runs of K.L. Rahul and the return of Rohit create a piquant situation. The skipper, though, is quick to sort the issue: "KL will open, and I will bat somewhere in the middle order. Personally, a tough choice, but this is what the team needs."

The second Test is all about local hero Travis Head, and his 140 deflates India while Mitchell Starc and skipper Pat Cummins strike with the ball. The host wins by 10 wickets,

Grand stage: At the picturesque Adelaide Oval, Australia defeated India by 10 wickets, levelling the series 1-1. GETTY IMAGES

and the series is level at 1-1. Spice too is evident as Head and Mohammed Siraj exchange words, and the ICC steps in with the penalties.

The Adelaide Oval is familiar territory for Nathan Lyon, having worked here as the ground staff more than a decade ago. "It is one of the finest wickets in the world, the best perhaps," Lyon tells the media. The current head curator, Damian Hough, has fond memories of the off-spinner's tryst with soil and grass. "Unbelievable story, isn't it? He worked hard, always had that cheeky humour, and we remain close," Hough says.

During the Test (December 6 to 8), the Indian scribes think they have seen an oasis as *daal* fry and chicken curry are sighted at lunch one day. Just that it proves to be a mirage as there is no accompaniment of rice. Buns are used to mop up the curries — not ideal, but a rumbling stomach has the last word! The unanimous verdict is that there is nothing like Indian hospitality back home.

It is time to wake up early and catch a morning flight to Brisbane.

This time around, Alex Carey is a co-passenger. Upon landing, he waits patiently for his luggage, nods to people who recognise him, speaks to the lone television reporter, and then gets into a cab and heads to the team hotel.

Pastoral and arboreal

There is humour that is entirely wicked and pure Australian. A billboard on one of the roads proclaims this about a specific hotel: "Worst vegetarian hotel in Brisbane." The tongue-in-cheek subtext, which is never said, is perhaps: 'Mate, if you are a carnivore, feel at home!'

A bunch of scribes retire to their country home. Trees abound, crickets lend a rhythmic acoustic beat, and at night, a pair of friendly eyes emerges within the foliage. Cat, a large squirrel — what is it? A close-up is sought, the shy animal obliges for a few seconds and then leaps onto the roof. Google is searched for assistance — it turns out to be an arboreal visitor called the common brushtail possum.

Ahead of the third Test at the Gabba, an accidental verbal duel crops up. Cummins speaks about replicating the short-ball strategy against India. Shubman Gill later retorts: "What is he talking about? They (at Adelaide) got tailenders and just one batter!"

